

compassion is a dish best served cold

There is a popular saying in my family:

כל המרחם על אכזרים סופו להתאכזר על רחמנים.

He who shows mercy on the cruel will end up being cruel to the merciful. or in other words: you can't show compassion to the people that mean to harm you. They bring up this passage every chance they get as an ultimate comeback to every discussion. This saying originated in Hazal and has developed from the biblical story of King Saul who mercied the Amalekim (the natives of Cnaan) and ended up slaughtering all of King David's supporters. Oh sweet irony. The beauty in this saying is that it shows how two completely separated events can combine into a dangerous phrase, and how it can lead the collective sense behind the scenes for ages. (especially during current events), needles to say that I hate this horrible gaslighting phrase. and every time someone brings it up it drives me crazy.

In these dark times, I'm having great struggles not to be completely absorbed into hatred. Although I still feel a strong connection to this place, culture and people. nationalism became a forbidden word and I feel like a teenager that wants to kill his parents. The people that are the closest to me disappoint me with their false perspectives. And in wandering around in the streets of my city I find only brutality and ugliness.

I assume you know Jerusalem, where I live, vaguely. Here it's like a chicken cage of Jewish orthodox and settlers terrorists. I want to paint you a picture of it through my eyes: Near a really hipster gallery venue which was an old palestinian residency, there is a big construction site for the third temple visitor center. in every corner of the main street of the city "Jaffa Street" there are displays of power and violence: from the soldiers making arrests while the seatellers youth vandalising arabs stores on Jerusalem's day. Every day the

beautiful old city is rising with rampage and sinking into a lull of reason. Even in the remote neighborhoods you can find visions of injustice made in the name of god: Palestinians workers crossing the borders to fall off construction sites for minimum wage.. the dirt is bubbling through the Jerusalem stone, dripping through the mass, blowing in their trumpets, celebrating another jewish holiday. a nightmare of a city.

I am walking through the streets and it seems that everyone is against me, they know who I am, they know my beliefs and they hate me for it, they hate me for less than my opinions, they hate me for my presence in their holiest of holies. And although i'm a really nice person, I can't compete with the absolute certainty of fulfilling God's demand.

It's hard not to hate people who think differently than you. it's harder when they are doing crimes in the name of their beliefs. Eduard Said wrote in an article that "criticism comes before solidarity". But I can't separate myself from the place I'm in, from my education, my culture, **my judaism**. All I can do is to stick to my truths, and thus loath the people that act differently, and in my opinion ruin every piece of this beautiful land.

To be honest, I'm ashamed, I'm not doing enough to stop the war crimes, I feel like I'm responsible for the crimes made by the Israeli government, made by the people around me. I'm ashamed of my country and therefore I'm ashamed of myself. At the same time a lot of people call me a traitor for feeling compassion with the enemy, even in my own family, this is the level of alienation we arrived at. the great love that i had for my people fades. instead of it I get carried in the circle of hate.

I can keep on walking in the streets of jerusalem and feel disgusted of any appearance of jewish solidarity, i can move to another country and alienate

myself completely from the people that I love. i can see them as my enemies and choose to endure their phrases and show no mercy on them.

But I can oppose with compassion to the people that violate the space i live in. I can look differently and watch the cancer running through the minds of the ignorants. With my eyes and heart wide open I see how hate for the other is created in me as well. I can see how my worship for enlightenment is very much alike of their worship for th jewish god. How every kind of blind worship leads to exercising power to those who believe differently.

In this crossroad of a time, when everyone around me makes extreme choices, my choice to stay in Jerusalem is rooted in the compassion of the cruel. I honestly believe that they don't need my compassion, they don't need me to stand and look at them while screaming, waving their hands, celebrating murder, but criticism from within cannot come without the understanding that we are poor, and the hatred comes from greater injustice which is not their fault.

I can't see a bright light at the end of the tunnel, each day things are getting worse in here, and hope fades into bloodlust in the name of revenge. I am only responsible for the change in me, and in choosing compassion for the people that are against me, I'm earning freedom. Im rising above the sewerage of Jerusalem.